

The Indian Passport & Visa Playbook

2026-27 Edition

Apply, renew and travel - the verified, step-by-step system
for your passport, your visa-free map and the big four visas.

Built from official sources - MEA | passportindia.gov.in | gov.uk
IRCC | US State Department | VFS Global | Henley Passport Index

How to use this playbook

This playbook does three jobs in one place. It walks you through getting or renewing an Indian passport under the rules that took effect on 1 July 2026. It gives you the honest 2026 map of where an Indian passport gets you in without a visa, where you get one on arrival, and where you must apply in advance. And it takes the four visas Indians apply for most - the United States, the United Kingdom, Canada and Schengen - and lays out each one step by step, with the current fee, the real waiting time and the refusal traps.

Everything here is drawn from official sources: the Ministry of External Affairs, passportindia.gov.in, the Passports (Amendment) Rules, 2026, gov.uk, IRCC (Canada), the US Department of State and VFS Global. Where a figure changes often - visa fees and appointment waits - the date it was verified is stated so you know how fresh it is. Nothing here is invented. If a number was not in an official source, it is not in this book.

The one rule that saves you weeks: apply for a passport or a visa the moment you know you will travel, not the week you want to book tickets. Every delay in this book traces back to applying late.

1 Jul 2026

NEW PASSPORT FEES

36-page passport is now Rs 2,500 normal, Rs 5,000 Tatkaal

5-6 days

AVERAGE PROCESSING

MEA's current target from application to dispatch

25 + 40

VISA-FREE + ON ARRIVAL

Destinations open to Indian passport holders (Sept 2026)

This is an independent guide. It is not affiliated with the Government of India, any embassy or any visa agency. Fees and rules change without notice - always confirm the live figure on the official portal before you pay.

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Chapter 8 is the one people skip and then regret. The waiting time for a US visitor-visa interview from India can run to a year at some consulates. Book the appointment before you plan the trip, not after.

1. What changed in 2026 - the three shifts

Three official changes reshape Indian passports this year. Know them before you spend a rupee or book a slot.

1.1 Passport fees rose sharply on 1 July 2026

The Passports (Amendment) Rules, 2026 (G.S.R. 516(E), notified 25 June 2026) replaced the fee schedule that had stood since 2012. Fees came into force on 1 July 2026. The rises are large - a standard 36-page passport went from Rs 1,500 to Rs 2,500, and the Tatkaal version from Rs 3,500 to Rs 5,000. The government cited the cost of chip-based e-passport booklets and the upgraded service programme. The full current schedule is in the table below.

Application (from 1 July 2026)	Normal	Tatkaal
Fresh / re-issue, 36 pages (18+ years)	Rs 2,500	Rs 5,000
Fresh / re-issue, 60 pages (18+ years)	Rs 3,500	Rs 6,000
In lieu of lost / damaged, 36 pages (18+)	Rs 5,000	Rs 7,500
In lieu of lost / damaged, 60 pages (18+)	Rs 6,000	Rs 8,500
Fresh / re-issue, 36 pages (minor, below 18)	Rs 1,750	Rs 4,250
In lieu of lost / damaged, 36 pages (minor)	Rs 4,250	Rs 6,750
Police Clearance / Surrender Certificate	Rs 750	Not available
Certificate of Identity	Rs 1,000	Not available

Tatkaal fees shown are inclusive of the normal fee. A 10% discount applies to fresh applications (not re-issue) for children up to 8 years and senior citizens above 60. Adult passports are valid 10 years; a minor's passport is valid 5 years or until they turn 18, whichever is earlier.

1.2 Every new passport is now a chip-based e-Passport

The Ministry of External Affairs completed the rollout of Passport Seva Programme 2.0 (PSP V2.0) across all 37 Passport Offices, 93 Passport Seva Kendras (PSKs) and 450 Post Office Passport Seva Kendras (POPSKs) on 26 May 2025, and the Global version (GPSP V2.0) at embassies and consulates on 28 October 2025. Going forward, every newly issued Indian passport is an e-Passport - a hybrid booklet with an embedded RFID chip and antenna carrying your data to ICAO standards. By mid-2026, roughly 1.47 crore e-Passports had been issued, about 10% of all active Indian passports.

- Your existing non-chip passport stays valid until its printed expiry date. You do not need to replace it early.
- PSP 2.0 brought a rebuilt website and mobile app, auto-filled forms, simpler document upload and UPI/QR payment.
- The passport itself is a travel document - the MEA has clarified it is not, by itself, proof of citizenship.

1.3 Faster processing and a widening network

The MEA has cut the average application processing time to about five to six days, and is pushing police verification toward two to three days nationally by replicating the best-performing states. The service network now stands at around 544 PSKs and POPSKs, up from just 77 a decade ago. In practice this means your job is to submit a clean file - the system moves quickly once the documents are right.

2. Fresh passport: the complete walkthrough

This is the exact sequence, from an empty form to a booklet in your hand. Follow the steps in order. The whole process is online until the day you visit a PSK.

2.1 Step 1 - Register and fill the form online

Create an account on the Passport Seva Online Portal (passportindia.gov.in). Register, log in, and choose 'Apply for Fresh Passport / Re-issue of Passport'. Fill the form carefully - what you type here is printed on the booklet, and you are responsible for its accuracy. Use the DD-MM-YYYY date format, choose 36 or 60 pages, and mark Normal or Tatkaal.

Two traps at this step. First, you must pick the PSK that matches your present address - each Regional Passport Office serves fixed PIN codes, and the wrong jurisdiction means your file is refused even if the centre is minutes from your home. Second, do not leave mandatory fields blank; an incomplete form is rejected at the counter with no second chance.

2.2 Step 2 - Pay and book your appointment

Online payment is mandatory for booking an appointment at every PSK, POPSK and Passport Office. You can pay by credit or debit card (MasterCard, Visa), internet banking (SBI and other banks), or UPI. After payment, book your slot and note your Application Reference Number (ARN).

- You must visit the PSK within 90 days of submitting the form online, or the application lapses.
- A no-show deletes your captured data - you would have to fill everything again.
- You may reschedule or cancel only twice within a year of your first appointment.
- Tatkaal and some categories (senior citizens, minors, differently-abled) can walk in with an ARN and no prior appointment, subject to the local Passport Office's advisory.

2.3 Step 3 - The PSK visit, counter by counter

Arrive at your appointment time with originals and one set of self-attested photocopies. A photograph is not needed - it is captured on site. Carry the ARN printout or the SMS with your appointment details; a printout is no longer mandatory.

- Counter A - your form and particulars are checked and any corrections made. Verify every detail here; this is your last easy chance.
- Counter B - documents are verified against the originals and scanned.
- Counter C - your photograph and fingerprints are captured.
- You are given an acknowledgement; the file then moves to processing and police verification.

Prohibited inside a PSK: laptops, iPads, cameras, and anything sharp or flammable. Leave them at home.

2.4 Step 4 - Police verification, pre or post

Most fresh passports are issued on a pre-police-verification basis: the police report comes before the booklet is printed. Under Tatkaal, verification is post-issuance - you get the passport first. How you are treated depends on your category, and you can influence it.

Your category	Document you submit	Verification mode
Government / PSU / statutory employee	Annexure A (Identity Certificate)	No police verification at all
Government / PSU / statutory employee	Annexure G (No Objection Certificate)	Post-issuance verification
Government / PSU / statutory employee	Annexure H (Prior Intimation Letter)	Pre-issuance verification
Everyone else (fresh passport)	Standard documents	Usually pre-issuance
Tatkaal applicants	Three acceptable documents (adults)	Post-issuance

To pass verification smoothly: keep a nameplate or flat number visible, make sure someone at the address can confirm you live there, and keep your phone reachable during working hours. The most common failure is not a missing document - it is a verification officer who could not reach you or your neighbour. If a report comes back adverse, contact your Passport Office; a re-verification can be requested, but you need a clear report for the passport to issue.

2.5 Step 5 - Dispatch and tracking

Once the file clears, the passport is printed and dispatched by post or courier, and you can track status on the Passport Seva portal using your file number and date of birth. A Tatkaal passport is normally dispatched within one to three working days of your PSK visit, without waiting for the police report. A clean normal application is now commonly dispatched in under a week. Complex cases - adoption, a major name change, doubtful documents - take longer, around 30 days.

2.6 Normal vs Tatkaal - when the extra fee is worth it

	Normal	Tatkaal
Fee, 36-page adult	Rs 2,500	Rs 5,000
Police verification	Usually before issue	After issue
Documents	Address + DOB + Non-ECR proof	Any three acceptable documents (adults)
Dispatch after PSK visit	Typically under a week	1-3 working days
Who cannot use it	-	Cases needing extra scrutiny (e.g. certain name changes)

Choose Tatkaal only when the timeline genuinely demands it. Since 2019, Tatkaal no longer needs a gazetted-officer verification certificate - you simply submit any three of the acceptable documents (adults), which is why it is faster to prepare than many people assume.

2.7 Filling the form field by field

The form is machine-read, so small formatting mistakes matter. Follow the instruction booklet's rules:

- Write in CAPITAL LETTERS throughout, inside the given boxes only.
- Do not overwrite. Strike out a wrong character and continue in the next box.
- Never write 'NA', 'N/A' or 'Not Applicable' in a box - leave it blank instead.
- Do not fold or smudge the printed form; it is scanned by character recognition.
- Write the date of birth as DD-MM-YYYY.
- Give your name exactly as you want it printed - surname and given name. No titles such as Major or Doctor. A surname may be two words (Roy Choudhary).
- Tick 'Yes' for an alias or a name change, and fill the Supplementary Form.
- For place of birth: if born in India, give the village/town/city, district and state; if born abroad, give only the country; if born before 15 August 1947 at a place now in Pakistan or Bangladesh, write 'Undivided India'.
- State the basis of citizenship - by birth, descent, registration or naturalisation.
- Fill PAN, Voter ID and employment type if you have them, then choose 36 or 60 pages and Normal or Tatkaal.

2.8 Choosing your office and booking a slot

Two kinds of office handle your application. A Passport Seva Kendra (PSK) or a Post Office PSK (POPSK) is where you submit and give biometrics; the Regional Passport Office (RPO) is where the file is actually processed. Your PSK must match the PIN code of your present address - not the office nearest to your workplace.

- Online payment is mandatory before an appointment is confirmed.

- You can check appointment availability on the Passport Seva portal.
- Tatkaal applicants and some categories (senior citizens, minors, differently-abled) may walk in with an ARN and no prior appointment, subject to the local office's advisory.
- If you are refused a token at the counter for missing documents, you may revisit the same PSK as a walk-in within the next three working days.
- You may reschedule or cancel only twice within a year, and a no-show deletes your captured data.

2.9 Reading your application status

Track your file on the portal with your file number and date of birth. The status moves through recognisable stages - submitted, under process, police verification initiated or clear, printed, dispatched, delivered. If the file pauses, look for an RPO remark (an objection) under the application remarks. It will name the problem - an address mismatch, a missing Annexure, a photo issue, a police report not clear - and that is your instruction for what to fix. Act quickly; a paused file does not move on its own.

3. The document set that decides your application

For a fresh ordinary passport you submit self-attested photocopies and carry the originals for verification. The core set is proof of present address, proof of date of birth, and - if you qualify - documentary proof for the Non-ECR category. This chapter lists what counts.

3.1 Proof of present address - any one of these

- Water bill, electricity bill, or gas bill (recent)
- Telephone bill - landline or postpaid mobile
- Photo passbook of a running bank account (a plain printed bank statement is not accepted)
- Rent or lease agreement, supported by a utility bill
- Aadhaar or other government photo ID showing the full present address
- For a minor, a present-address document in a parent's name is accepted

3.2 Proof of date of birth - the rule depends on your birth date

If you were born before 1 October 2023, any one of the following is accepted, as long as it carries your full date of birth:

- Birth certificate from the Registrar of Births and Deaths or the municipal body
- School leaving or matriculation certificate from a recognised school or board
- PAN card issued by the Income Tax Department
- Government service record, or pension payment order for retired employees
- Driving licence issued by a state transport department
- Election Photo Identity Card issued by the Election Commission of India
- LIC policy bond showing the policyholder's date of birth

If you were born on or after 1 October 2023, only the birth certificate from the Registrar of Births and Deaths is accepted. If the certificate does not carry the child's name, attach a declaration on plain paper signed by the parents.

3.3 The Non-ECR proof (why it matters)

Indian passports carry an ECR (Emigration Check Required) or Non-ECR tag. Certain categories of applicants - for example, those with qualifying educational qualifications, income-tax payers and specified professionals - are eligible for the Non-ECR category. The Passport Seva portal's Document Advisor tells you, from your own answers, whether you qualify and which document to attach. Do not guess; run the advisor. If you are eligible and want the Non-ECR tag, attach the proof.

3.4 Re-issue document set

- Your old passport in original, with self-attested photocopies of the first two and last two pages, including the ECR/Non-ECR page and any observation or validity-extension pages
- Proof of present address - only if it differs from the old passport
- PAN card
- Any additional document the specific change requires (name change, DOB change, etc.)

The mismatch rule, again: your name, your parents' names and your date of birth must read identically across every document. Even one letter of difference between your Aadhaar, PAN and school certificate can freeze the file at the counter or fail police verification. Fix the spelling on the documents before you apply, not after.

3.5 The Annexures explained

Annexures are the supplementary forms that decide how your file is treated. Get the right one for your category from the portal's Document Advisor.

Annexure	What it is	When you use it
Annexure A	Identity Certificate	Government / PSU / statutory employees - passport issued with no police verification
Annexure G	No Objection Certificate	Government employees - verification after issuance
Annexure H	Prior Intimation Letter	Government employees - verification before issuance
Annexure F	Employer verification letter	Commonly required for Tatkaal applications
Annexure L	Declaration for a lost passport	Attached with the police complaint / FIR

Other annexures cover specific situations such as a name change or single-parent consent for a minor. Do not guess which one applies - run the Document Advisor, which returns the exact list for your case.

4. Re-issue, renewal and the special cases

4.1 When to re-issue - and when police verification is waived

You re-issue a passport rather than apply fresh when the booklet has expired or is about to, when its pages are full, when it is lost or damaged, or when you need to change personal particulars. The useful rule: apply up to one year before expiry, or within three years after expiry, and you avoid fresh police verification provided your previous police report was clear and there is no adverse entry. Expired more than three years ago - expect fresh verification.

4.2 Lost or damaged passport

A lost passport is re-issued on a fresh police-verification basis, and you will need a police complaint or FIR and a declaration. Damaged booklets are treated similarly and cost more - see the fee table in Chapter 1. Report a passport lost abroad to the nearest Indian mission immediately and get an Emergency Certificate to travel home.

4.3 Changing your name, address or date of birth

Any change to personal particulars is done through a re-issue, not a fresh application. A change of name after marriage, or a corrected spelling, needs supporting proof and often a newspaper or Gazette notification. Date or place of birth changes face the strictest scrutiny and can be refused if the evidence does not match. Plan extra time for all of these.

4.4 Passports for minors

- A minor's passport is valid 5 years, or until the applicant turns 18, whichever is earlier.
- Present-address proof can be in a parent's name.
- Carry originals and self-attested copies of the parents' passports if they hold one, and proof of the parent-child relationship.
- The child is treated as Non-ECR until age 18.
- For children up to 8 years, a 10% fee discount applies on fresh applications.

4.5 Senior citizens and government servants

Senior citizens above 60 get the same 10% discount on fresh applications and may walk in without a prior appointment at many centres. Government, PSU and statutory employees should use Annexure A, G or H to control whether police verification happens at all - it is the single biggest lever they have.

5. Understanding your passport booklet

A little passport literacy prevents most confusion at the border. Here is what each part of the booklet means.

5.1 The passport number and validity

An Indian passport carries a unique alphanumeric number, and a validity period - ten years for adults, five years (or until 18) for minors. Several countries require your passport to remain valid for at least six months beyond your planned return date, so a passport with less than a year left is often already too short for a long trip. Renew early.

5.2 ECR and Non-ECR

ECR stands for Emigration Check Required. It applies mainly to applicants who have not passed Class 10, and it means certain overseas employment destinations require an emigration clearance from the Protector of Emigration before you can take up a job there. Non-ECR passports carry no such restriction. The tag is about employment emigration, not tourism - but it is worth knowing which one you hold before you accept an overseas job offer.

5.3 The observation page

If the Passport Issuing Authority has ever added a remark - a name change, a correction, a short-validity extension - it appears on the observation page. Officers abroad read this page. If a change you need is not reflected there, you need a re-issue.

5.4 The e-Passport chip

The chip stores the same data printed on the data page, digitally signed, and is read by tapping the booklet at immigration. The gold symbol under the front cover marks an e-Passport. The data is read-only and is matched against your stored biometrics - which is what makes the new system far harder to forge.

6. The 11 rejection traps - and the fix for each

Almost every delayed or rejected passport file fails for one of these reasons. Read the fix column before you apply; each one costs nothing to get right and weeks to get wrong.

The trap	The fix
Name mismatch across Aadhaar, PAN and birth proof	Make the spelling and initials identical on every document first
Address that does not match your Aadhaar or bill	Use one proof whose name and PIN code match the form exactly
Wrong PSK / RPO jurisdiction for your PIN code	Book only the centre that serves your present address
Blank mandatory fields (marital status, place of birth)	Fill every field; blanks are refused at the counter
Photo not to MEA spec (shade, colour background, wrong size)	White background, full face, no shadow - the photo is captured at the PSK, so dress plainly
Missing Annexure for your category	Carry the right Annexure (A, G, H, F, L) for your case
Blurred or low-resolution document scans	Scan clean, colour, straight - never a phone photo of paper
Date of birth differing across records	Reconcile DOB across birth certificate, marksheets and ID
Police officer cannot reach you or your neighbour	Keep a nameplate visible and your phone reachable in work hours
Reusing a document that was already rejected once	Get a fresh, matching document before reapplying
Applying too late for your travel date	Start the moment you know you will travel - not when you book tickets

One warning that carries real weight: under the Passports Act, 1967, giving false information or suppressing a material fact to obtain a passport is punishable with imprisonment up to two years, a fine, or both. Never 'adjust' a detail to fit. Fix the underlying document instead.

7. Where can you go without a visa? The 2026 map

The headline number you see quoted for the Indian passport changes depending on who is counting and what they count. Here is how to read it, and where you can actually go.

7.1 Why the numbers differ

The Henley Passport Index counts visa-free entry, visa-on-arrival and basic electronic travel authorisations together, and excludes full eVisas. Under that method, India ranked 75th in February 2026 with access to 56 destinations, and sat around 82nd with 55 destinations by August 2026. A separate September 2026 ranking counts 25 strictly visa-free destinations, 40 visa-on-arrival and 5 eTA. India also has a large set of destinations available on a full eVisa - useful, but a different category, because an eVisa still needs an online application before you fly. Read the category, not just the number.

7.2 Visa-free destinations (no visa before departure)

Destination	Permitted stay
Nepal	No limit (bilateral)
Bhutan	Entry permit required on arrival
Mauritius, Seychelles	Up to 90 days (Seychelles: free visitor permit on arrival)
Malaysia	Up to 90 days, with a Digital Arrival Card
Thailand	Up to 60 days, with an arrival card
Maldives	Up to 90 days
Kazakhstan	14 days (max 42 days in any 180)
Philippines	14 days
Rwanda, Angola, Gambia, Senegal	30-90 days
Fiji, Vanuatu, Kiribati, Micronesia, Cook Islands, Niue	30-120 days
Barbados, Dominica, Grenada, Haiti, Jamaica	90 days to 6 months
Trinidad & Tobago, St Vincent & the Grenadines, Montserrat	90 days to 3 months

Several of these are time-limited programmes that are re-checked every few months. Confirm current rules before booking.

7.3 Visa on arrival

A visa is issued when you land, usually for a fee. The official MEA list runs to about 40 destinations. Stays range widely:

Visa on arrival	Permitted stay
Armenia	Up to 120 days
Azerbaijan	30 days
Cambodia	30 days
Comoros	45 days
Djibouti	90 days
Ethiopia	90 days
Gabon	90 days
Guinea-Bissau	90 days
Indonesia	30 days

Visa on arrival	Permitted stay
Jordan	30 days
Laos	30 days
Madagascar	90 days
Marshall Islands	90 days
Mauritania	90 days
Mongolia	30 days
Morocco	30 days
Myanmar	30 days
Nigeria	90 days
Palau	30 days
Russia	30 days
Saint Lucia	42 days
Samoa	90 days
Sierra Leone	30 days
Tanzania	On arrival
Timor-Leste	30 days
Togo	15 days
Tuvalu	30 days
Uzbekistan	30 days
Vietnam	90 days
Zimbabwe	90 days

Some entries on the MEA list have conditions - for example, Myanmar's facility is time-limited, and Cambodia may ask for proof of accommodation, a return ticket and evidence of funds. Re-check the destination's own immigration page before you fly.

7.4 The conditional-entry gotcha

Several attractive destinations grant visa-on-arrival or visa-free entry to Indians only if you already hold a valid visa or residence permit from the US, UK, Schengen, Canada, Australia, Japan or a GCC state. The table below shows the common ones.

Destination	Qualifying condition for Indians
United Arab Emirates	Valid US / UK / Schengen / Canada / Australia / NZ / Japan / Singapore / South Korea visa or residence permit
Saudi Arabia	Valid US, Schengen or UK visa, already used at least once; digital stamps not accepted
Bahrain	Valid UAE, UK, US, KSA (non-Hajj) or Schengen visit visa, or a US Green Card
Oman	UK, US, Australia, Japan or Canada visa, or GCC nationality
Armenia	Valid residence permit from the US, EU, UAE or GCC states for the long visa-free stay
Egypt	Valid US, Schengen, UK or GCC visa, already used at least once

Read the condition, not the headline. If you are counting on a conditional visa-on-arrival route, the qualifying visa must be valid, and for some countries already used. A digital visa stamp may not be accepted. Check the specific condition before you rely on it.

7.5 Popular destinations - what Indians need

A quick orientation for the places Indians travel to most. Categories shift, and several are conditional - treat this as a starting point and confirm on the destination's official immigration page.

Destination	Entry route for Indian passport holders (2026)
Thailand	Visa-free, up to 60 days (arrival card)
Malaysia	Visa-free, up to 90 days (Digital Arrival Card)
Maldives	Visa-free, up to 90 days
Mauritius, Seychelles	Visa-free, up to 90 days
Kazakhstan	Visa-free, 14 days
Sri Lanka	Visa / ETA required before travel
Singapore	Visa required before travel
United Arab Emirates	eVisa, or visa on arrival with a qualifying US / UK / Schengen visa
Japan	eVisa available
Vietnam, Indonesia	Visa on arrival / eVisa
Russia, Azerbaijan	eVisa or visa on arrival
Kenya	Electronic Travel Authorisation (eTA)
Egypt	eVisa, or visa on arrival with a qualifying US / UK / Schengen visa

Rules here change more often than any other part of this book. Verify the current position on the destination's immigration website and the MEA's list before you pay for a flight.

8. The four big visas, step by step

These are the visas Indians apply for most, and the ones where a mistake costs the most time. Fees and waits are current as verified in September-October 2026; always confirm on the official portal before you pay.

8.1 United States - the B1/B2 visitor visa

- **Fee:** USD 185 (non-refundable, non-transferable), paid in rupees at the consular exchange rate - about Rs 96 per dollar as of April 2026.
- **Step 1:** Complete the DS-160 form online at ceac.state.gov. It takes about 90 minutes; it times out on inactivity, so gather your details first.
- **Step 2:** Pay the fee through the official USTravelDocs portal and keep the receipt.
- **Step 3:** Book two appointments - biometrics at a Visa Application Centre, then the interview at the embassy or consulate. Both are booked on ustraveldocs.com; email requests are not accepted.
- **Step 4:** Attend biometrics, then the interview. Indians are typically granted a 10-year, multiple-entry B1/B2.
- **Step 5:** If approved, the passport is retained and returned by courier or pickup within a few business days.

Visitor-visa interview waits by city (US State Department, September 2026):

Consular post	Average wait	Next available
New Delhi	7.5 months	10 months
Mumbai	11 months	11.5 months
Hyderabad	11.5 months	12 months
Chennai	7 months	7.5 months
Kolkata	Around 4 months	Around 4 months

Student and exchange visas (F, M, J) are far quicker - often one-and-a-half to two-and-a-half months - so a student should not read the visitor numbers as their own. A refusal under section 214(b) means the officer was not convinced you would return; you may reapply any time with stronger evidence. Eligible applicants may qualify for an interview waiver, which does not appear in the wait-time table. Request an expedited slot only after you hold a regular appointment - medical emergencies, funerals and school start dates qualify; tourism does not.

8.2 United Kingdom - the Standard Visitor visa

- **Fee:** GBP 135 for up to 6 months (about Rs 17,854). Long-term: GBP 506 (2 years), GBP 903 (5 years), GBP 1,128 (10 years).
- The 6-month fee rose from GBP 127 to GBP 135 on 8 April 2026 and was unchanged at the 8 October 2026 revision.
- **Where:** Apply online at gov.uk, then give biometrics at a VFS Global centre in India. You cannot apply directly to the High Commission.
- **Timing:** You may apply up to 3 months before you travel. The standard decision target is 3 weeks (15 working days) from biometrics.
- **Speed:** Priority service adds GBP 500 (5 working days); Super Priority adds GBP 1,000 (next working day).
- **New:** Since 25 February 2026, most visitor visas issued to Indians are eVisas linked to the passport - you will not get a sticker.
- **VFS service fees** of roughly Rs 3,000-5,000 apply on top.

The refusal killer: unexplained large deposits. Caseworkers read your six-month bank statement as a story of steady income. A large lump sum that appears with no prior pattern is the single most common reason Indian applications are refused. Build a consistent six-month pattern of salary credits and normal spending before you apply.

8.3 Canada - the Temporary Resident Visa (visitor visa)

- **Fee:** CAD 100 per person (CAD 500 for a family of five or more). Biometrics: CAD 85 per person, CAD 170 per family.
- **Where:** Apply online through IRCC, then give biometrics at a Visa Application Centre. You must have the visa before you depart - it cannot be issued on arrival.
- **Timing:** Processing varies by visa office and season; incomplete files are refused. Give biometrics as early as possible - processing starts only after they are received.
- **What they may ask for:** an interview, extra documents, a medical exam or a police certificate.
- **If approved,** you get a letter asking you to submit your passport; the visa is placed in that passport. Submit the same passport you applied with.

8.4 Schengen - the short-stay visa for 29 European countries

- **Fee:** EUR 90 for adults (since 11 June 2024); EUR 45 for children 6-12; free under 6. VFS service fees of roughly Rs 2,000-4,000 apply on top.
- **Where:** Apply at the consulate of the country where you will spend the most nights, through VFS Global or BLS. Biometrics are mandatory and in person.
- **Insurance:** Travel medical cover of at least EUR 30,000, valid across Schengen, is required.
- **Timing:** Apply up to 6 months ahead and no later than 15 days before travel. Standard processing is about 15 working days; peak season can stretch it to 45 days.
- **Documents that decide it:** a stable six-month bank statement, an employment letter with approved leave, income-tax returns for the last two to three years, proof of property or ties in India, and a clear day-by-day itinerary with confirmed hotel bookings.

Two Schengen facts people get wrong. First, ETIAS - the EU's new pre-travel authorisation - is for visa-exempt nationalities, not for Indian citizens; you still need a full Schengen visa. Second, the promised paperless EU visa portal is expected to begin a phased rollout from around September 2026, but until it is live you still apply through VFS and the consulates exactly as before.

8.5 What each officer weighs most

Every visa has one question at its centre. Aim your file at it.

Country	What carries the most weight	The fastest way to fail
United States	That you will return - a stable job, family, property and prior travel	Vague answers, or a plan that assumes you will stay
United Kingdom	A consistent six-month income story	An unexplained large deposit just before applying
Canada	Purpose of visit, funds and ties to India	An incomplete file, or funds that do not match the trip
Schengen	Traceable income and income-tax returns	Missing ITRs, or income that cannot be traced

9. The cover letter and the interview

Two soft skills decide more visa outcomes than people expect: a clear cover letter and a calm interview. Neither is about clever wording - both are about consistency.

9.1 The cover letter that works

A cover letter is not a formality; it is where you make the officer's job easy. Keep it to one page and use this structure:

- **Who you are** - name, passport number, occupation, employer, city.
- **Why you are travelling** - the exact purpose, in one sentence.
- **When and where** - the dates and the itinerary, matching your bookings exactly.
- **Who is paying** - you, your employer or a sponsor, and how you fund the trip.
- **Your ties to India** - your job, your family, your property, your reason to return.
- **The documents enclosed** - a short list, so nothing is missed.

Consistency is the whole game. The dates in the cover letter, the hotel bookings, the flight reservations and the application form must agree to the day. Contradictions between the form, the letter and the documents are a leading cause of refusal - not weak income alone.

9.2 The US interview - what they actually ask

The interview is short, usually a few minutes. The officer is testing one thing: whether you will return. Prepare honest, specific answers to these.

- What is the purpose of your trip?
- How long will you stay, and where?
- Who is paying, and what do you do for a living?
- Have you travelled abroad before?
- Do you have family in the United States?
- What ties do you have to India - your job, your home, your family?

Answer briefly and truthfully. Carry evidence for what you say. Do not volunteer documents nobody asked for, and never memorise a script - officers notice. If your circumstances are genuinely strong, the answers take care of themselves.

9.3 The core document bundle - prepare it once

The same bundle of documents strengthens all four visas. Assemble it once and reuse it, updating the dates.

Document	Why it matters
Passport, plus every old passport	Identity, and the travel history consulates value
Recent photographs to spec	Needed for the application and the visa
Bank statements, six months, stamped	Proof you can fund the trip
Income-tax returns, two to three years	Proof of traceable income - decisive for Schengen
Employment letter with approved leave	Proof of a job to return to
Proof of ties: property, family, investments	Proof you will come back
Confirmed accommodation and itinerary	Consistency with the dates you claim
Travel insurance	Mandatory for Schengen; wise everywhere
A one-page cover letter	Ties the whole file together

Build the bundle, not the story. A file that is thin on paper but consistent beats a thick file full of contradictions. Officers read for consistency first and completeness second.

10. What it all costs, end to end

Budgeting for a passport and a visa is more than the headline fee. Here is the full picture, with the add-ons that surprise people. Rupee figures are approximate and move with the exchange rate - confirm on the official portal.

Item	Government / consulate fee	Service + extras	Indicative total
Passport (36-page adult)	Rs 2,500	-	Rs 2,500
Passport Tatkaal (36-page)	Rs 5,000	-	Rs 5,000
US B1/B2	USD 185 (~Rs 17,760)	VAC biometrics free	About Rs 17,800
UK Standard Visitor	GBP 135 (~Rs 17,854)	VFS Rs 3,000-5,000	About Rs 21,000-23,000
Canada visitor visa	CAD 100 + CAD 85 biometrics	VFS service fee	Convert at current rate
Schengen short-stay	EUR 90 (~Rs 8,500)	VFS Rs 2,000-4,000 + insurance Rs 1,500-3,000	About Rs 12,000-16,000

Two hidden costs worth planning for. Travel insurance is mandatory for Schengen and wise everywhere - budget Rs 1,500-5,000. And travel itself should be booked refundably until the visa is in hand: a full ticket bought before approval is money at risk if the visa is delayed or refused.

11. Travel-day essentials

A valid passport is not enough on its own. These are the rules that stop people at the gate.

11.1 Passport validity and blank pages

Many countries require your passport to be valid for at least six months beyond your planned return, and to have at least two blank pages for stamps. Check the specific requirement for your destination - it is the destination that sets it, not India. Renew early if your passport is within a year of expiry.

11.2 Transit, ETAs and eVisas

Even a short connection can need its own permission. The UK has a transit visa for landside transit, and a Direct Airside Transit visa for some nationalities. Many countries now issue an eVisa or an electronic travel authorisation (ETA) linked to your passport rather than stuck in it - check that your airline can see it at check-in, and carry the approval printout anyway.

11.3 Travel insurance

Schengen requires a minimum of EUR 30,000 medical cover. Even where it is not mandatory, buy it: a single overseas hospitalisation can cost more than every other item in your trip combined. Read what is excluded before you buy.

11.4 Travelling with a minor

A child travelling with one parent, or with neither, may be asked for a notarised consent letter from the other parent, plus proof of relationship. Carry copies; immigration officers abroad can and do ask.

11.5 If you lose your passport abroad

Report it to the local police and to the nearest Indian embassy or consulate immediately. You will need a police report and proof of identity to be issued an Emergency Certificate, which lets you travel home. This is another reason to keep a scanned copy of your passport and visa in cloud storage you can reach from any device.

11.6 The week before you travel

- Recheck passport validity - six months beyond return, and two blank pages.
- Print the visa, eVisa or ETA approval and carry it with your passport.
- Carry proof of accommodation and a return ticket.
- Carry your travel insurance policy and the emergency helpline number.
- For a minor travelling with one parent, carry the notarised consent letter.
- Keep both digital and paper copies of your passport, visa and insurance.
- Check security and baggage rules, and reach the airport with time to spare - immigration may ask about your purpose and your funds.

12. The checklists

Tick these off before each appointment. Print this page if it helps.

12.1 Passport application day (PSK visit)

- ARN or appointment SMS
- Originals of every document, plus one set of self-attested photocopies
- Proof of present address matching your PIN code
- Proof of date of birth per the correct list
- Non-ECR proof, if you qualify
- The right Annexure for your category (A, G, H, F or L)
- Nothing electronic or sharp in your bag

12.2 US B1/B2

- DS-160 submitted; confirmation page saved
- USD 185 fee paid; receipt kept
- Biometrics (VAC) and interview both booked
- Proof of ties to India: job, property, family, savings
- Bank statements and income-tax returns
- Travel plan and purpose clear and consistent

12.3 UK Standard Visitor

- Online application complete; GWF reference saved
- GBP 135 fee paid; VFS biometrics booked
- Six-month bank statement with a steady income pattern
- Employment letter with approved leave dates
- Accommodation and itinerary evidence
- Consistent answers across form, cover letter and documents

12.4 Canada visitor visa

- Online IRCC application submitted
- CAD 100 fee plus CAD 85 biometrics paid
- Biometrics given early at a VAC
- Proof of funds, ties and purpose of visit
- Passport ready to submit once approved

12.5 Schengen

- Applied at the correct consulate (most nights)
- EUR 90 fee; VFS appointment booked up to 6 months ahead
- Travel insurance of at least EUR 30,000
- Six-month bank statement and 2-3 years of ITRs
- Employment letter with leave approval; NOC if senior
- Day-by-day itinerary and confirmed hotel bookings
- All old passports included

12.6 Official portals - bookmark these

Only these are authoritative. Anything else that charges to 'process' what you can do yourself is a risk.

What you need	Official portal
Passport application, fees, tracking	passportindia.gov.in
Visa-free / visa-on-arrival list for Indians	mea.gov.in/vffin
NRI passport applications	embassy.passportindia.gov.in
US visa - DS-160, fees, appointments	ceac.state.gov ; ustraveldocs.com
UK visa fees and process	gov.uk/standard-visitor ; visa-fees.homeoffice.gov.uk
Canada visitor visa	canada.ca (IRCC)
Schengen applications in India	vfsglobal.com

13. Scams and 'guaranteed visa' agents

The passport and visa space attracts fraud because the stakes are high and the rules look complicated. A few rules keep you safe.

- No one can guarantee a visa. The decision rests with the consulate alone; any agent who promises approval is either lying or planning to submit a fraudulent application in your name.
- Use only official portals - passportindia.gov.in for passports, gov.uk, canada.ca, ustraveldocs.com and the consulate/VFS sites for visas. The US Embassy states its information is free of charge and warns against third-party sites that charge to 'process' what you can do yourself.
- Never hand over original documents you cannot replace, and never let anyone fill a form with details that are not true - the applicant is legally responsible for every line.
- Be wary of 'visa-free' or 'visa-on-arrival' claims for a destination that actually requires a prior visa. Verify against the MEA's own list before you pay for a flight.
- Report fraud to the local police and to the embassy or consulate concerned.

14. Applying from abroad - for NRIs

If you live outside India, you apply through the Global Passport Seva Programme (GPSP V2.0), launched at Indian embassies and consulates worldwide on 28 October 2025. Register on the Global Passport Seva Online Portal, choose your country of residence, and follow the mission's local instructions.

- Document rules are broadly the same, but your mission may require notarised or apostilled copies of documents from your country of residence.
- Fees abroad are set separately - the fee schedule lists them in US dollars.
- Police verification, where required, is handled through the mission's process rather than a state police station in India.
- For a lost passport, report to the local police and the mission; an Emergency Certificate lets you travel back to India.

If your country is not listed on the Global Portal, you may have to apply through the 'background check in India' route, following the online form submission process. Your nearest Indian mission is the final authority on which route applies to you.

15. Nine myths that cost people money

'A passport proves I am an Indian citizen.'

The MEA has clarified it does not. A passport is an international travel document. Citizenship is established by other records.

'I must replace my old passport with an e-Passport now.'

No. Existing passports remain valid until their printed expiry. Only new passports are chip-based.

'Tatkaal still needs a gazetted officer's certificate.'

It has not since 2019. Adults now submit any three acceptable documents.

'A bank statement is fine as address proof.'

A printed bank statement is not accepted. A photo passbook of a running account is.

'I can apply at the PSK closest to my office.'

No. Your PSK must match the PIN code of your present address. The wrong jurisdiction gets your file refused.

'An agent can guarantee my visa.'

No one can. The consulate alone decides, and a fraudulent application is your legal responsibility.

'Indians can enter Schengen on ETIAS.'

No. ETIAS is for visa-exempt nationalities. Indian citizens need a full Schengen visa.

'A US visitor visa takes a few weeks.'

B1/B2 interview waits from India ran from about four months to around a year in September 2026. Book early.

'I can travel on a passport valid for only three months.'

Many countries require six months beyond your return and two blank pages. Check the destination's rule.

16. Your 90-day action plan

Work backwards from your travel date. This is the sequence that keeps you ahead of the queues.

When	What you do
Days 0-3	Decide passport (fresh or re-issue) and visa type. Check passport validity - six months beyond return, two blank pages.
Days 3-10	Reconcile your documents: make name, parents' names and DOB identical across Aadhaar, PAN, birth proof and address proof.
Days 10-20	File the passport application (or, if you already hold one, start the visa application). For the US, book the interview now.
Days 20-45	Attend the PSK visit; complete biometrics for any visa. Build a steady six-month bank statement pattern for the UK, Canada and Schengen.
Days 45-70	Track the passport; submit the visa file with insurance and itinerary. Book refundable travel only.
Days 70-90	Receive the passport and visa. Confirm the visa's validity dates and every detail printed on it before you book non-refundable tickets.

The single most valuable habit: book the appointment before you plan anything else. For the US especially, the interview wait - not your documents - is what decides whether you travel on time.

17. Questions people ask most

Do I have to replace my old passport with an e-Passport?

No. Existing passports stay valid until their printed expiry date. Only newly issued passports are chip-based e-Passports.

How long does a normal passport take now?

The MEA's current average is about five to six days from application to dispatch for a clean file, and police verification is being cut toward two to three days. Complex cases take longer.

Is Tatkaal worth the extra fee?

It is, when your timeline is tight. It uses post-issuance police verification and dispatches in one to three working days after your PSK visit. It no longer needs a gazetted-officer verification certificate.

Can I apply for a passport without an address proof?

No - proof of present address is mandatory. Use one whose name and PIN code match your form exactly.

Why was my passport file put on hold?

The usual reasons are a name or address mismatch, a missing Annexure, a blurred document scan, or a police report the officer could not complete. Check the remark against your application and fix the underlying document, not the form.

How far ahead should I apply for a US visitor visa?

As far as you can. B1/B2 interview waits from India ran from about four months (Kolkata) to around a year (Hyderabad, Mumbai) in September 2026. Student visas are much faster.

Do I need a visa for Schengen if I have an ETIAS?

ETIAS is for visa-exempt nationalities. Indian citizens still need a full Schengen visa.

What is the biggest cause of UK visitor-visa refusals?

Unexplained large deposits in the bank statement, and weak ties to India. Build a consistent six-month income pattern before applying.

Which countries can I visit without any visa?

Around 25 destinations are strictly visa-free (Nepal, Bhutan, Mauritius, Malaysia, Thailand, Maldives and more), with roughly 40 more offering a visa on arrival. Some visa-on-arrival routes are conditional on already holding a US, UK or Schengen visa.

What is ECR, and does it stop me travelling?

ECR means Emigration Check Required. It mainly affects certain overseas employment destinations, not tourism. Check your passport's tag and, for a job abroad, whether an emigration clearance applies.

Can I apply for a passport if I have never had an address in my name?

For adults, present-address proof is mandatory; a rent agreement with a utility bill or a government photo ID showing the address works. For minors, a parent's address proof is accepted.

How much does a lost-passport re-issue cost?

For an adult 36-page booklet, Rs 5,000 normal or Rs 7,500 Tatkaal since 1 July 2026, and it is processed with fresh police verification.

Do I need to carry my old passports to a visa appointment?

For Schengen, yes - consulates want your previous passports and travel history. For others, carry them if you have them; they strengthen your file.

Is it safe to use a visa agent?

Use an agent only for clerical help, never for a 'guarantee'. No one can promise a visa, and a fraudulent application is your legal responsibility.

What if my name is spelled differently on different documents?

Reconcile it before applying. A single letter of difference can freeze the file. Where you cannot, an affidavit or a corrected document is the fix - not a 'close enough' form entry.

When should I renew a passport that is about to expire?

Apply up to one year before expiry, or within three years after, to avoid fresh police verification. Many countries also need six months' validity beyond your return, so renew a year out if you travel often.

18. Glossary of passport & visa terms

The acronyms that appear on forms, portals and refusal letters, in plain English.

Term	What it means
PSK / POPSK	Passport Seva Kendra / Post Office PSK - where you submit and give biometrics
RPO	Regional Passport Office - where your file is processed and the passport issued
ARN	Application Reference Number - your application's ID after online submission
ECR / Non-ECR	Emigration Check Required / not required - mainly affects certain overseas jobs
e-Passport	Hybrid booklet with an embedded RFID chip holding your data
DSC	Digital Signature Certificate - needed by professionals certifying incorporation forms
MRV fee	Machine-Readable Visa fee - the US nonimmigrant visa application fee
DS-160	The online US nonimmigrant visa application form
VAC	Visa Application Centre - where biometrics are collected for several countries
VFS Global / BLS	The outsourced partners that collect visa applications in India
TRV	Temporary Resident Visa - Canada's visitor visa
Schengen	The 29-country European area with a single short-stay visa
ETIAS	EU pre-travel authorisation for visa-exempt nationalities - not for Indian citizens
ITR	Income-Tax Return - a key proof of income for UK, Canada and Schengen files
NOC	No Objection Certificate - often needed from an employer
Section 214(b)	The US law under which a visitor visa is refused for insufficient ties to home

Keep this page. Half of the confusion in a visa or passport file comes from not knowing what a portal is asking for. This glossary turns the jargon into plain instructions.

19. Sources and how to verify

Every factual claim in this playbook traces to an official or primary source. Because fees and wait times change, here is where to confirm the live figure before you act.

Topic	Official source
Passport fees, forms, documents, e-Passport	passportindia.gov.in ; MEA press releases ; Passports (Amendment) Rules, 2026 (G.S.R. 516(E))
Visa-free and visa-on-arrival list	Ministry of External Affairs - 'Visa facility for Indian Nationals' (mea.gov.in/vffin)
Passport strength ranking	Henley Passport Index 2026 ; Passport Reports (September 2026)
US visa fees, process and wait times	travel.state.gov ; ustraveldocs.com ; in.usembassy.gov
UK visa fees and process	gov.uk ; visa-fees.homeoffice.gov.uk ; VFS Global India
Canada visa fees and process	canada.ca ; IRCC (ircc.canada.ca)
Schengen fees and documents	VFS Global India ; European Commission Visa Code ; consulate sites
Global / NRI applications	Global Passport Seva Programme (embassy.passportindia.gov.in)

Verification note: passport fees, visa fees and appointment waits were verified against the sources above in September-October 2026. Fees change without notice. Treat every number here as a starting point and confirm the current figure on the official portal before you pay.

Thank you for reading. If this playbook saved you a rejected application, a wasted PSK trip or a missed appointment, it has done its job. Travel well.